

Week 4: Origins of Nigerian Societies

JSS1 Nigerian History — First Term Lesson Note (Deep-Dive Edition)

Introduction

Many Nigerian societies have traditional stories, known as **myths of origin**, that explain how their people and kingdoms came to be. These stories are treasured parts of cultural heritage, passed down through oral tradition, even where they cannot be verified as literal historical fact.

The Yoruba Myth of Origin

According to Yoruba tradition, **Oduduwa** descended from the heavens at Ile-Ife, sent by the Supreme Being, and became the first divine king (Oni) of the Yoruba people. Ile-Ife is regarded as the spiritual birthplace of the Yoruba, and many Yoruba kingdoms — including Oyo, Ketu, and others — trace their royal lineage back to Oduduwa's descendants.

The Hausa Myth of Origin

The Hausa trace their origin to the legend of **Bayajidda**, a heroic prince said to have travelled from the east, married into the ruling family of Daura, and whose sons and grandson founded the original seven Hausa states, known as the **Hausa Bakwai** (Daura, Kano, Katsina, Zazzau, Gobir, Rano, and Biram).

The Igbo Origins

Unlike the Yoruba and Hausa, the Igbo do not have one single, widely-shared origin myth. Different Igbo communities trace their beginnings through various local traditions, including migration accounts (such as the tradition of **Eri**, an ancestral figure associated with the founding of Igbo-Ukwu and the Nri kingdom). This reflects the traditionally **decentralized** nature of Igbo society, made up of many independent communities rather than one central kingdom.

Other Origin Myths

The **Benin** origin tradition tells of the youngest son of Osanobua (the Supreme God), who received a snail shell containing sand; when poured onto the primordial waters, the sand formed dry land, and this son became the first ruler of Benin. Similar creation and migration themes appear in the origin traditions of many other Nigerian peoples.

Real-Life Application

These myths of origin still shape Nigerian identity today — for example, many Yoruba obas trace their ancestry to Oduduwa during coronation ceremonies, and the historic Hausa Bakwai states remain culturally significant reference points in Hausa identity.

Vocabulary

Word	Meaning
Myth of origin	A traditional story explaining how a people or place came into existence

Lineage	A line of descent from an ancestor
Decentralized	Not governed from one single central authority

Evaluation Questions

- 1 According to Yoruba tradition, who was Oduduwa?
- 2 Where did Oduduwa reportedly descend to, according to the myth?
- 3 Who was Bayajidda, according to Hausa tradition?
- 4 Name the seven original Hausa states (Hausa Bakwai).
- 5 Why does Igbo society not have one single shared origin myth?
- 6 Who is Eri, according to one Igbo tradition?
- 7 Describe the Benin myth of origin involving Osanobua's youngest son.
- 8 Explain the difference between a myth of origin and a verified historical record.
- 9 How do myths of origin still influence Nigerian culture today?
- 10 In your own words, explain why oral traditions like these are valuable, even without full historical proof.

(Week 5 is Midterm Test — revision of Weeks 1–4 content.)